

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Define the three Mauryan endings

DYNASTY: Mauryan ruling line ends at Pataliputra

EMPIRE: territorial integration weakens unevenly by region

INSTITUTIONS: offices, routes and practices are adapted or abandoned

LEGACY: scripts, monuments, memories and political ideas persist

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232 BCE = Ashoka's death; not the instant end of all four processes.

A decline answer must identify which object it is explaining.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Why Mauryan rule was historically significant

MAURYAN SIGNIFICANCE

- |-- virtually subcontinental political horizon
- |-- routes, provincial nodes and differentiated administration
- |-- earliest large corpus of royal public inscriptions
- |-- dhamma as public ethical-political argument
- |-- monumental stone, pillars, caves and stupa patronage
- `-- long memory in Buddhism and modern national symbolism

QUALIFY: unprecedented scale did not mean equal direct control everywhere.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Post-Ashoka chronology and thin evidence

232 BCE: Ashoka dies

-> later ruler lists diverge

Dasharatha: Nagarjuni cave inscriptions provide direct evidence

-> short reigns and declining royal epigraphic visibility

c. 187/185 BCE: conventional Brihadratha-Pushyamitra transition

Evidence thins before the final coup; silence is not a complete narrative.

Dynastic termination at the centre followed earlier regional weakening.

Use approximate dates and identify textual versus inscriptional evidence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Weak successors: useful trigger, incomplete cause

EVIDENCE: many short reigns + succession uncertainty + epigraphic thinning

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POSSIBLE MECHANISM: court conflict -> unstable appointments -> weaker loyalty

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LIMIT: later lists do not grade each ruler's competence

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VERDICT: succession shocks likely mattered through institutions and regions.

They do not alone explain frontier pressure, provincial agency or continuity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Centralisation and differentiated-control debate

OVER-CENTRALISED MODEL

court instability spreads fast
appointments depend on centre
distance strains command

DIFFERENTIATED CONTROL MODEL

local mediation reduces daily central burden
provinces retain adaptive capacity
detachment becomes easier when prestige falls

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 \-- COMMON TEST ---/

information, revenue, coercion and legitimacy must still reach strategic zones.
Decline may reveal both top-heavy dependence and strong regional intermediaries.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Fiscal and economic crisis hypothesis

LARGE ARMY + OFFICIALDOM + MONUMENTS -> HIGH IMPERIAL COSTS

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plausible fiscal pressure and extraction problems

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BUT no direct treasury record proves terminal bankruptcy

AND towns, trade, coin use and agrarian expansion continue regionally

VERDICT: fiscal strain is a mechanism to test, not a demonstrated general crisis.

Do not use debasement or donation claims without dated evidence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Ashokan pacifism hypothesis under evidence test

CLAIM: dhamma and nonviolence weakened military preparedness.

COUNTER-EVIDENCE:

- Rock Edict XIII retains warning to forest peoples

- army and coercive offices were not abolished

- Pillar Edict IV presupposes punishment and capital penalty

SAFE VERDICT: renunciation of aggressive conquest may affect frontier posture,
but no evidence shows total demilitarisation or a helpless state.

Ethical policy and coercive sovereignty coexisted.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Brahmanical reaction hypothesis under evidence test

CLAIM: sacrifice restrictions and heterodox patronage caused Brahmana revolt.

POSSIBLE: some ritual specialists may have faced grievance.

COUNTER:

- edicts repeatedly respect Brahmanas and shramanas

- no direct evidence proves an empirewide organised reaction

- Dasharatha continued Ajivika patronage after Ashoka

Pushyamitra's identity and rites do not by themselves explain earlier decline.

VERDICT: bounded grievance hypothesis, not a proven monocausal revolution.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Regional agency and frontier pressure

NORTH-WEST: distance + Bactrian Greek pressure + changing frontier alliances

KALINGA: conquered region requiring corrective governance

DECCAN/SOUTH: differentiated penetration and growing regional capacities

GANGA CORE: court succession and dynastic termination

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regional elites redirect revenue, troops and legitimacy

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Empire fragments through several theatres; one cause cannot fit all regions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Multi-causal decline mechanism

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SUCCESSION SHOCKS ---- weak coordination ---- provincial assertion
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fiscal/extraction strain -- communication costs -- frontier pressure
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      \----- declining coercive and symbolic integration -----/
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                uneven imperial fragmentation
Final coup ends dynasty; it does not single-handedly cause the whole process.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Continuity through transformation

SANCHI: Ashokan brick core -> Shunga enlargement -> later gateways and shrines

SARNATH: lion capital -> modern national emblem

EPIGRAPHY: Brahmi and royal inscriptional visibility continue in new genres

ROUTES/TOWNS: material networks outlive the dynasty unevenly

RELIGION: Buddhist, Ajivika and other institutions continue and change

POLITY: regional states reuse selected capacities, not a complete Mauryan template

Continuity is adaptation and reinterpretation, not unchanged survival.

Political fragmentation can coexist with economic and cultural persistence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Examiner-ready significance and decline spine

INTRO: separate dynasty, empire and legacy; date Ashoka's death and final boundary.

BODY 1: significance in scale, inscriptions, dhamma, routes and monuments

BODY 2: succession and institutional vulnerability

BODY 3: fiscal, pacifism and Brahmanical-reaction hypotheses tested

BODY 4: regional agency, frontier pressure and differentiated chronology

COUNTER: thin sources and continuing economy/culture

CONCLUSION: interacting causes dissolved integration; legacy survived selectively.

WRITE: hypothesis -> evidence -> mechanism -> counter-evidence -> graded verdict.